

HOUSEBOUND

DESIGN DOCUMENT

Version 1.0



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GAME CONCEPT

INTRODUCTION Housebound is a short psychological horror experience where players explore an abandoned house, uncovering clues and unraveling a mysterious story through environmental storytelling and unsettling atmosphere . The project is a solo indie project released on itch.io .

GENRE & PLATFORM

- **Genre:** First-Person Psychological Horror .
- **Platform:** PC (Windows) .
- **Engine:** Unity .
- **Target Audience:** Horror players seeking short, atmospheric, story-driven experiences .

HIGH CONCEPT Housebound is a short psychological horror experience where players explore an abandoned house, uncovering clues and unraveling a mysterious story through environmental storytelling and unsettling atmosphere .

KEY FEATURES (GAME PILLARS)

- **Atmosphere-Driven Horror:** Tension created through lighting, sound, and environment .
- **Psychological Fear:** No combat; fear comes from presence, ambience, and the unknown .
- **Exploration & Story:** Players uncover the narrative through clues and rooms .
- **Short, Replayable Experience:** Designed for quick, impactful horror sessions .

CORE GAME PLAY

GAME MECHANICS

- **Movement:** First-person movement (WASD + Mouse Look) .
- **Interaction:** Interaction system: Open doors, inspect items, read notes .
- **Physics:** Basic physics-driven interactions (doors, objects) .
- **Response:** Environmental cue response (lights flicker, sounds play) .
- **Combat:** No combat or health system — pure survival/exploration .

GAME FLOW (CORE LOOP)

1. Enter the abandoned house .
2. Explore rooms and hallways .
3. Search for clues and story elements .
4. Experience scripted and environmental horror events .
5. Piece together the narrative .
6. Reach the final reveal or ending .

ART AND VISUAL STYLE

ART DIRECTION

- **Style:** Realistic low-poly/medium-poly interiors .
- **Lighting:** High contrast lighting with heavy use of shadows and fog .
- **Palette:** Dark greys, browns, cold blues .

ASSETS & PROPS

- Old furniture .
- Dust particles .
- Damaged walls, debris .
- Broken lights, candles .

SOUND AND MUSIC (AUDIO DESIGN)

OVERALL GOALS Silence is as important as sound . Audio builds anxiety and directs the player .

SOUND EFFECTS & MUSIC

- **Ambience:** Ambient droning (low frequencies) .
- **Foley:** Footsteps, creaks, door sounds .
- **Horror Cues:** Distant whispers / subtle horror cues .
- **Dynamics:** Sudden silence moments .
- **Music:** No background music except tension peaks .

STORY

PREMISE The player awakens inside an abandoned house with no memory of how they arrived . Through found notes and environmental hints, they reconstruct the tragedy that occurred .

NARRATIVE DEVICES

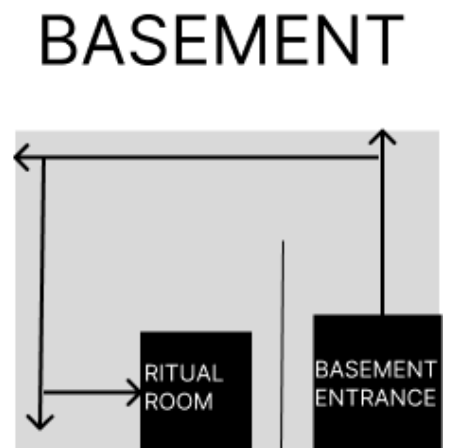
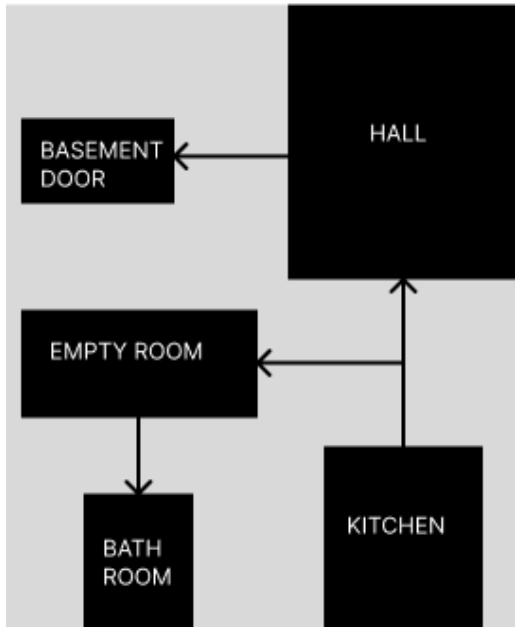
- Notes .
- Environmental storytelling .
- Sound cues .
- Object placement and thematic symbolism .

TONE & ENDING

- **Tone:** Dark, slow-burn psychological tension with minimal jump scares .
- **Ending:** Player uncovers the final clue revealing what happened inside the house, concluding the short narrative experience .

LEVEL OVERVIEW (ENVIRONMENT DESIGN)

APARTMENT LEVEL LAYOUT



SETTING & LAYOUT

- **Setting:** Dark, abandoned single house with multiple rooms .
- **Layout:** Linear but encourages exploration of each room .
- **Lighting:** Low intensity, flickering bulbs, shadows .

HORROR CUES Creaking floors, distant knocks, whispers, sudden ambience shifts .

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

SYSTEMS

- Interaction system .
- Trigger-based event system .
- Audio zones .
- Lighting events (flicker, blackout) .
- Clue collection system .

PERFORMANCE & OPTIMIZATION

- Baked lighting where possible .

- Limited dynamic shadows .
- Low polycount props .
- Optimized textures (compressed) .
- Culling and occlusion for interior rooms .
- **Build Size:** ~99 MB .

FUTURE EXPANSION POTENTIAL

- Additional endings .
- More clues and narrative layers .
- Expanded house layout (attic, basement) .
- Improved cinematic sequences .
- Updated sound design for deeper immersion .
- Optional stalker entity for advanced tension .